

Not all Tea and Scones

Jim Schembri, Reviewer
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Awfully boring television - unless you're into pudding.

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For far too long the Country Women's Association has been burdened with the stereotype that it is just a gaggle of rural women whose main preoccupation in life is making tea and scones.

Such a distorted view is overdue for correction, so with that myth-busting brief very much front of mind, the intrepid Carmel Travers seeks to enlighten us all. There is much more to the Country Women's Association than tea and scones. There's pudding too. Also, the scones come with jam and cream. Whether coffee is available as well as tea is not made clear in part one of the four-part series, but all indications are that this pressing issue will be dealt with at some point.

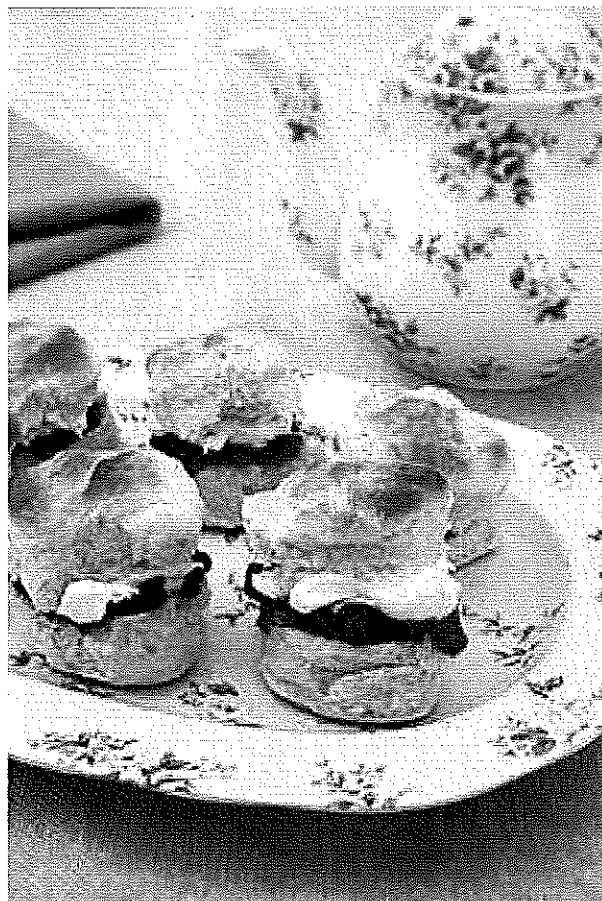
But back to the pudding. Not just any old pudding will do when it comes to pudding competitions held by the Country Women's Association. Standards are high and if the pudding is not up to scratch, well, it just won't get in. Such a devastating moment is captured on camera, so those with a sensitive nature are duly warned.

Fascinatingly, not just members of the CWA can make puddings and scones. Everybody can. Thus, as various association members pound away in their kitchens, we are given the recipes on screen. (Note: no mention is made of these recipes being available on a program-related ABC website, so be sure to record the show, just in case.)

The first episode of *Not All Tea and Scones*, enticingly titled *Madame President* and the *Showgirls*, presents a fleeting profile of Judy Richardson, who is the state president of the CWA in NSW and who seems to have a few things on her mind other - repeat, other - than tea and scones.

Even more fleeting is the mention made of the political clout the CWA has and the important role it has played in improving the lot of those in the bush regarding dental services, child care, road safety and crisis relief.

This is the stuff we want to hear more about - but forget that. Let's get back to the kitchen and



The scones come with jam and cream at the Country Women's Association

spend more long minutes watching how a pudding is made. There may be more to the association than tea and scones but, according to what is presented here, there's not a lot more. If anything, the program confirms the stereotype it sets out to combat. Plus, it's awfully boring television. Unless you're into pudding.

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I'm a shocking starrer. When someone sparks my interest, I'm seized by desperate curiosity, a need for behind-the-scenes information and the stupid hope it will magically appear if I keep looking. People simply fascinate me.

Imagine my delight when I boarded a flight and noticed the woman across the aisle was wearing a niqab, swathed completely in black with only her eyes showing through a slit. She was travelling with her husband and their three kids and I was beside myself with fascination.

I've only ever had two opportunities to look closely at someone in a niqab. Both times in shops. The first was at Gap in Paris when a dozen refrigerator-sized men wearing earpieces walked into the store ahead of five veiled women.

The bodyguards fanned out, surrounding the women who wandered around excitedly, choosing T-shirts, maternity jeans and accessories. All I could see were their hands, which were decorated with some serious sparklers. Their eyes sparkled too.

A few years later, in my local Best & Less, two women walked in wearing niqabs. After they left, I overheard the woman in front of me say to the sales assistant: "Goodness, I was worried they were going to blow us up!" I cringed at this, appalled.

Still, like many, I've always suspected that women who wear niqabs are oppressed, and mind-controlled by extremist husbands, fathers and other male relatives.

Now on the plane, I was within a couple of feet of one such woman and I had eight hours to consider her plight. Here are some of the things I thought:

Poor thing. Her husband must be a scary man.

How sad for her children to not see their mother's face in public. What must that little girl think about her own future?

I wish I could talk to her and liberate her from this oppression.

I wonder what she thinks of me sitting here in my singlet and cardi with my fluoro purple bra strap showing.

When I glanced back shortly after take-off, I was shocked to notice she'd taken off her face veil. I was also confused. Didn't women wearing niqabs believe it was wrong to have strangers see their face? Should I look away?

A bit before we landed, I fell into conversation with her husband, Emad, who offered me some of his daughter's chocolate when my son began to cry.



ILLUSTRATION EMMA THOMSON

Within three seconds, I asked Emad about his wife, who was sleeping. "I noticed she took off her niqab after she got on the plane," I began. "How come?" He smiled. "Because I asked her to." I looked at him quizzically and he rolled his eyes in that affectionately resigned way spouses often do. "I hate it! She wants to wear it all the time and I wish she wouldn't!"

Emad met his wife, Houda, in Beirut when she was 18. Soon after, she migrated to Australia and they married. Now she was 26, he was 29 and they have three kids. After their first child was born, Houda put on the niqab. Her husband was not happy with her decision but Houda was insistent and eight years later, her will still prevails.

By now Houda had woken up and joined the conversation, laughing and teasing her husband as we chatted.

"Emad told me you love to shop. But ..." I gestured to her niqab, "you can't see it!" "I buy jewellery and bags," she replied, "and different coloured veils."

The couple explained there was division in the Muslim community over the niqab. Some of their own family were horrified when Houda chose to wear it. "What can I do?" shrugged Emad. "It's her decision."

I turn to Houda. Why do you want to wear it? "I just feel naked without it. Not right. I like it! Even though it would be so much easier to take it off. People give you bad looks always. Swear at you. I've had it pulled off my face before." She seems untroubled by all this and I feel my preconceptions about her float away as we chat.

A week later, boarding our flight home from Borneo, I noticed another woman, also wearing niqab. This time I didn't stare. I didn't need to. I knew there was no great threat or mystery underneath her veil. ■■■

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United States

PAUL MILENSKI

Lost Keys

The old dziadz was always the first out of the car, heading downstream, fishing as rapidly as the flow of water until he put some distance between him and me. I used to kid him about it in the company of my brother when all three of us went ice fishing together, standing out on early ice, three figures suspended above water on crystal, waiting for red-flagged signals on our tips. "Maybe that's why you never took to trout fishing, Ron, the old dziadz does not like to keep company. Isn't that right, dziadz?"

"Together, you just scare fish on a stream. You need distance. You know that."

"Ron's sociable, that's why he likes it on the ice."

"He's right, dziadz. When I went with you, I felt like a horse left at the gate."

"Either you fish right or you don't."

The old dziadz drove, had his boots on, his pole put together, the crawlers in a shirt pocket. After he parked the car near the stream, he tossed you the keys and he was gone. "I'll catch you later."

MILENSKI / *Lost Keys*

Then, in an hour or two, he would appear quietly, instantaneously, like a stag poking its head through the brush, taking you by surprise. "How you doing?"

After his retirement, he slowed down a little. Once he fell on a slippery rock, broke his glasses. Another time, he got caught in the middle of the stream in a swirling current, filled his boots, had to carry half the stream with him to make it to shore. Then, he turned his ankle terribly when he dropped himself from a high bank to the stream bed.

He began to keep the keys. I asked why, and he said, "So you won't have to worry about them."

The last time out it rained. A cold rain, hard and steady. I caught lots of browns, orange-bellied, hook-jawed. They were right in the middle of the stream, in the rain-swollen currents. You had to get in there, fight the swiftness of the water.

We did not meet on the stream as usual. When I returned to the car, he was already there. He was sitting on the wet ground, his back up against a wheel hub. His clothes were soaked, his hair matted down, his curl gone. His lips were blue.

"Did you limit out already?"

I am sure he heard me.

"Did you quit early?"

His voice was barely audible. "I lost the car keys."

He was somewhere on the stream, so he said, reaching into his pockets for a handkerchief to wipe dirt from his eyes because he was whipped by a streamside branch. That's when he realized he did not have the keys.

"Maybe you locked them in the car?"

He said he had already checked, through the foggy windows, the ignition, the car seat, the mat. He had traced his path along the stream, back and forth. No keys.

"I swear I'm losing everything lately."

"One set of keys—that happens."

"Now what are we going to do?" He made a face that I'd never seen him make before; there was so much pain in it. His lips were twisted, his eyes almost pressed closed by the compression of his skin.

I suggested we walk to the nearest house, call my brother, ask him to deliver a spare set of keys. He did not like this idea. I said we could hide our equipment under the car or in the brush, bum rides, be driven back later. This was no good. I asked if he wanted to look some more; maybe two of us working together would spot them. No, his looking had been enough.

What was left?

"I deserve to be left out here in the rain."

"What kind of talk is that?"

"I'm losing everything lately."

"I'm not listening to that."

"It's true."

"No it's not. Jesus, one set of car keys."

"I don't even remember taking them out of the ignition. That's the real truth of it."

"Check your pockets again."

"I did."

"Inside your boot. Maybe they fell in there, are hooked over the leg strap."

"I'd feel them there, wouldn't I? Wouldn't I feel them there, rubbing against my leg?"

"Maybe not."

"I would hear them jingle, I think. Wouldn't I hear them when I walked?"

Then, unaccountably, he moved back down to the stream, staring blankly into the water.

I noticed the keys. They were lying near the wheel hub, where he had sat on them, in the indentation from the weight of his body.

I called to him, told him when he came back that he had given them to me, and I had forgotten. But I saw clearly that this did not work. He dropped his head as though it were a burden, spent a lot of time on this our last trip together standing in the rain, continuing to look at the ground, not wanting to be the first to take his pole apart, not wanting to leave.

'It's almost mornin', an' ya been stealin' again, Elgin!' 'Ow can I go to sleep, with yaself moonin' all over the countryside?' she cries. 'Ya only come out of jail last month, too. Ya *want* ole Fathers to flog ya again, or what?'

And Elgin was going to ride into camp on his white horse and unload all the beer. Everyone was going to gather around, and there would have been jokes and laughter and fun. His woman would have smiled at him and hugged him, and forgiven him—because he had brought some light into the dusty reserve.

He digs his hand into a pocket and pulls out one of Caesar's necklaces. His feral eyes meet her bruised ones.

'I got ya this, Maydene,' he mutters.

'Ooohh, Elgin! What ya tryin' to do to me, boy?' she weeps.

Elgin gets up abruptly, and moves outside. Muffled sobs pierce him like the first shafts of the orange-red sunlight from the new day.

HERBIE

THERE weren't many Abos in our town; only the Corriganans and Herbie's lot and, as the Corriganans and Herbie's cousins were all grown up, Herbie was the only boong to go to our school. Perhaps this is why we all taunted and teased him, because he was different and us kids don't like anything different.

Since this is all about Herbie, I reckon I'd better have a go at describing him. But this is real hard, because he was all thought: I mean, like, he'd look at you with those big, brown scowling eyes and he'd look right into you, so anything you knew, he'd know. Those eyes seemed to take up almost all of his face, then the nose, flat as a board and all nostrils, took up the rest. You never noticed his mouth, because he rarely spoke and never smiled. He'd flit around the shadows like a crow—he was black as one, too. His legs were long and thin like a crane's and his arms were long and skinny. His hands were abnormally big and his fingers long, so he was clumsy. He wasn't big and he wasn't strong, Herbie, and they reckoned that was because he never got enough to eat. But he was an Abo, and they never do.

Whenever he came to school, he'd only sleep, so it weren't really much good him coming. And us blokes used to smash him up, every break. Once the three Morgan boys locked him in the boys' dunny and left him there all day. The next day he was caned for six for wagging school, but he never told. That was the good thing about Herbie: no matter what happened to him, he never told—not even on me, and I was one of the worst.

Herbie was a bad scholar, but there were many other things he

could do well. No one but Herbie knew where all the wild bees hid their sweet, rich, brown honey. No one but Herbie knew where to get the baby rabbits in spring, or where the foxes hid in holes in the Dongeran hills. Only Herbie knew where the ducks laid their eggs or where the kangaroos grazed. Only the thin, silent outcast could climb to the top of the highest trees and get the young birds or eggs out of the nests. And he knew where the few emus we still had in the district hid among the pink salmon gums. But most of all only Herbie, out of all of us blokes who had lived in the bush all our lives, really understood the hidden feelings of our land—or his, really, I suppose. I mean, like, he'd spend hours staring at a plant or pretty flower; he could lie still, hidden in the tall yellow grass, watching wild animals all day, and they wouldn't know. Or, if they did, they never ran away. They were his mates and they, too, seemed to shrink away from us white fellahs: shy, silent and wild.

Yeah, we used to give that kid hell. Just some of the things we used to do was bury him in the sand by the footy goals or tie him up to the old bent redgum, by the hut in the middle of the playground where we'd have our tucker. Once me and Joey Gruger the German kid stuck him in a petrol drum and rolled him down Mile Hill. He went full belt into a black stump at the bottom, which must have nearly killed him. Then we all got around him while he sat on his knees and chucked up all over the ground. We laughed and Ally Moore rubbed Herbie's face in the chunder and we laughed even louder. I reckon we all feel bad about that now.

We used to chase him around the footy oval, but usually we gave up before he did, because he was a good runner. Only Herbie could run ten miles non-stop—well, he had to, didn't he, to get away from us blokes. But once we got him stumped when Kelly Ryan bought his Dad's best stockwhip to school, and we all ran behind him, lashing him, just like mad old Jay Hiskee did to his horses in the team he still used.

Once we went too far, when Alffe Morgan painted 'boong' all over Herbie's books: then his two brothers painted 'boong' all over Herbie, stripping the frightened boy naked 'like a proper nigger ought to be' as Jimmy, the wit of the Morgans, said. That night Dad brought a rumour home with him from the pub, that the Warandas (that's Herbie's family) had had a fight with the four Morgans—old Evan and his three boys, and had won, too, but since Dad was drunk as he could be, I hadn't believed him. But the next morning, when I saw Alf's face and the way Jimmy limped

and the fact that Mick, who always came to school if only to annoy Herbie, was absent, I knew the old man was right. None of us asked the Morgans, of course, but the word went around the school.

I reckon we was scared a bit after that, but summer come on and Willy Harris nearly drowned Herbie in the waterhole and nothing happened to the Harrises. Of course nothing would, if the Warandas had any brains. There were only four Warandas now, since Dallas was in Freo, and ten Harrises. Still, being scared never really stopped us from bullying the thin, silent Herbie but the Morgans let up a bit.

The Morgans lived on the other side of the railway from the Warandas. Old Evan owned a couple of sheep and a cow, and a vicious Alsatian-Labrador. The dog was a real racist because he hated the Warandas. One day, Herbie was daydreaming along the street when the dog rose from the shade of the Co-op wall and charged him. Herbie got a bad bite on the leg, which left a white semi-circular scar. The dog chased the boy up a gum tree and kept him there for an hour before going away. The next morning the dog was found stiff as a drunk man, with a dirty big stake sticking in him. No one really knew who done it of course, 'cept old Morgan reckoned he knew. So that's why the Morgans and Warandas was at war.

Like I said before, Herbie wasn't liked by us bigger blokes, but not all the school was against this lonely outcast. The little kids liked him, and he loved little kids. He would show them baby rabbits and foxes and birds, he would carve them toys out of wood—and he was a good carver, too. He made my brother a real beaut dingo standing on a rock and I reckon all his skill must have gone into making *that* little figure. But that's because he really adored my little brother. Yeah, Herbie loved the young 'uns of our town.

Then come the day I aren't never going to forget. It was hotter then hell, and everything sort of wilted in the hot, white glare of the sun. It was after school, and us kids was all out around Herbie; pushing him around until he got so dizzy he fell on the ground. All us boys were showing off to the girls, who shrieked their applause like a mob of cockatoos. Suddenly big, shaggy Kevin Andrews, who had brains the size of a sheep turd and a face like a cowpat, yanked the scared kid to his feet and boomed out, 'Yer gunna climb Big Smokey, boong, or I'll piss all over yah an' smack yah flaming face in. Orrright, yah black c—t?'

new torture sounded good fun so, with Andrews dragging the sorry, skinny figure, we all set off for Big Smokey.

I suppose I ought to tell you what Big Smokey is or else you won't see the whole point of this new ordeal we was about to put the kid through. See, there's this big old pine tree, dead as Banjo Patterson, right outside of town, a mile off. No one knows how it got there, but it must be a hundred years old, and it's a good hundred feet high. Once when it was still alive, a fire come through and burned it. They reckon it smoked for three months and whether this is dinkum or not, us kids give it the name of Big Smokey. But, you see, no one was allowed to climb it on account of it being rotten.

Well, we got there and the jagged framework of Big Smokey towered away up into the sky. The tallest building in town was the pub, which was thirty feet, and only Ally Moore, who reckoned he was tough, had ever climbed onto the roof. We was all quiet while we waited for Kevin to do something. I reckon the dopey bugger was feeling bad at sending the kid up the tree, but to stop now would mean being beaten by a blackfellow, so he grunted, 'Get up that tree an' climb to the top, yah black bastard. If yah don't, me an' the others will be waiting 'ere for yah, see? An' this time, we'll give yah one proper workin' over.'

Herbie was packing them, but he scurried up the tree. When he got out of our reach, he turned and scowled and called us names, so we got him with boondis and honky nuts. Mick Morgan hit Herbie fair on the bonce, so he climbed higher.

He kept right on climbing till he was well over halfway, until he was just a thin black speck on the greater, thicker, black trunk of the tree. All us kids was silent as a graveyard because we was sort of awed by the way he had beaten all us white blokes the way he had climbed so high.

Then, of course, it happened. None of us saw him grab the rotten branch, because the dying sun was in our eyes, but we seen him fall one hundred feet. He come down, breaking the smaller branches and bouncing off the bigger ones, then he hit the ground—splat! His yell sort of stopped halfway down, and then there was only silence except for a few girls screaming, us blokes with indrawn breaths, and Kevin Andrews chucking up.

Course, we'd nearly all seen an animal die, and the Harris's and Ashtons had seen humans die—the Harris's Mum, who took a month to die of cancer; and Johnny Ashton's brother, who fell

among the plough. We was all old enough to know what death meant. But Herbie was different, because we all knew he should never have climbed the tree and we all knew we'd killed him.

I don't know if you can picture our return to town. At first we were too scared to touch the still, crumpled black body, then Joey Gruger took off his grey greatcoat, which his dad had had in the German army, and placed it over Herbie's body. After that, Skinner Flynn, whose Dad was a roo shooter, and Mick Morgan got their sheath knives out and we made a sort of stretcher. We put him on it, then we sort of went home.

It's funny, but the only thing I thought of as we went home was that day, maybe two years back, when I had mucked up the kid's new shirt. You see, old man Waranda was on the dole and he never got much money; all he did get went on beer or V.O. port. All Herbie wore, summer or winter, were a pair of dirty blue levis and an old T-shirt. Then one day he come to school in a new red-and-white check shirt. He was real proud of that shirt: we could see by the way he kept touching it with his hands, like it was a young rabbit, or fox, or bird, or something. Well, at break, us kids surrounded him and belted him up a bit, then I yanked him up off his feet and I said something like, 'This shirt's too good for a dirty black boong like you, so I reckon I'll have it.' Then I tore it off him and messed it up, then ripped it up and laughed into his face. He cried a bit, but he was an Abo so didn't cry for long—he only hated me. I see now that it must have been the only absolutely new thing his family or anyone had ever given him.

The kids from town decided to go down to Waranda's house on Saturday. They didn't know what it was: curiosity, a chance to say 'sorry' or perhaps just something to do. The drooping gum trees along the dusty main street threw haphazard shadows onto the brown grass patches or white hot pavements. Down in the pink dam by the railway crossing, the water was still and flat, unbroken by the usual crowd of happy young children fishing or swimming. Today all the kids were at Waranda's house, down opposite the line.

They had been there before, to the drab, faded weatherboard house. Then they had gone laughing, with pockets full of boondis to hurl at the large, lumbering Mrs Waranda, in the red-spotted dress she always wore. But today there were no cries of, 'Boong-man, boong-man; the Warandas are all boongs,' or, 'Tommy

"Waranda is a drunk old boong bugger," or, "Come out an' fight, yah stropky black bastards."

Today the children were stealthy, guilty and silent, because Herbie was dead and they had killed him.

The house stood on bare, grey sand. Over by the wood heap, a chainsaw stood alone, unattended. The peppermint tree by the verandah drooped in the midday sun that shone viciously from a cruel blue sky. The battered old ute of many colours, the Warandas' transport, stood underneath the crooked twisted tree. Once, there had been a chook yard under the trees too, but the chooks had all died or been eaten; now remained only a broken, rusted wire fence, a lopsided tin shed, where snakes and spiders lived, and a big, white heap of manure.

All so quiet in the middle of the day.

The children stood around, staring. In there: in that dark, dirty house lay Herbie. It was hard to realise that the boy who had been so well and truly alive only yesterday afternoon, was dead.

Suddenly, old Mrs Waranda was framed in the rotten, grey doorway. The children scattered like chaff in the wind and only the yellow dust from their feet remained. The dust and the boy.

He was big and strong and brown, the boy, but he looked small in the emptiness now all his friends had gone. He was almost six feet tall, with curly hair and hazel eyes, one of which was pulled down in a squint.

For a long moment, he and Mrs Waranda stared at each other, the boy with a shifty, guilty, perhaps embarrassed look; she with a sour, sad, beaten look. Suddenly the boy looked up and moved to the dogleg fence. It seemed the Aboriginal woman retreated a little into the house. The boy cried, "Hey, Missus Waranda, I got somphin' for Herbie. For his grave, like, from us fellahs up home."

For a bit Mrs Waranda hesitated, then the fat old woman moved down the wooden steps and waddled across the brown dust patch. She reached the boy and looked up at him with fear in her eyes—and with just the faintest trace of hate. Mrs Waranda had never hated anyone, really. She was too humble and afraid to hate the white kids who teased her, and the white men, who had put her oldest boy in jail on a false charge, and the white women who stared at her as though she was the filth of the nation. But I knew she hated the white kids who had killed her youngest son.

The boy reached into his bike basket and pulled out a bunch of wild flowers, wilting now from the sun, and pushed them into the

scarred black hands. The boy mumbled, embarrassed now. "From me an' Malcolm, Missus Waranda."

The faintest trace of a smile flitted across the woman's thick, purple lips and she said, softness and tears in her big, brown eyes, "You a good boy, Davey Morne, you and ya little brother, Malcolm." And how I wish she could have been speaking the truth about me.

Rhinoceros Beetle

Susan Hawthorne

It was a public holiday on the day that he was born. His mother took this as a good omen. She failed to notice the reason for the holiday.

The day he began school he took with him his pet: a rhinoceros beetle. Over an extended period he had a series of beetles which accompanied him. Each day his little wooden box went with him and each day a rhinoceros beetle was inside the box.

His teachers thought him somewhat odd because he knew so much about some things, and so little about others. But the little girls knew otherwise.

The teachers always called on him during Nature Study to explain the life cycle of butterflies, grasshoppers, liver flukes or beetles. He would get carried away by his task and enter every detail - his eyes burning ferociously.

The town he lived near was home to two milk bars, two hotels and on the other side of the street were the railway station and a sugarcane mill. It was one of those towns that have a river for three months of the year and a bridge built to sustain the big floods every fifteen years.

The boy lived beyond the town's borders and grew up without companionship, aside from the ubiquitous rhinoceros beetles and a range of other insects, reptiles, stuffed birds and a cat that refused to be held in his arms. The garden being more than large enough to swing a cat, he had done precisely that.

In the spring he added to his large collection of eggs; raiding nests and blowing out the yolks; or he netted butterflies, pinning them stretched out, covering the boxes later with a non-reflective glass.

In the wet, when the grasshopper plagues descended, he would spend hours removing their legs, attempting to outdo his previous day's record. In the years when grasshoppers were relatively few, he found other creatures to entertain him or made do with his rhinoceros beetles.

In the dry of the winter he would ambush frogs and those little lizards that dispense with their tails when grabbed.

Each season provided him with new ways of frightening the little girls who sat in front of him or behind him in the school by the river.

When he was fifteen his biology teacher showed him how to keep the heart of a frog beating, exposed for all the world to see. Encouraged by his enthusiasm, the teacher suggested he stay on after school and learn the technique. By the time he went home he had learnt how to split the thoracic cavity and pin the limbs without spilling any blood.

At seventeen he left, complaining that the town was too small for him. From time to time he returned accompanied by various young women who invariably left him following the holiday.

The townspeople lost track of him, though occasionally his promising career would be mentioned in passing. All they knew about him now was their recollection of a taciturn and perfectionist child. At least, that is all they talked of openly. Those little girls who had fought not to sit next to him in the classroom held their secrets. They remembered the jabs, the sharp pain from beside or behind. They recalled the grasshopper legs in the back of their summer dresses. They remembered too, the terrible threats he made, the tales he told of

poison gathered from his rhinoceros beetles, or the fangs of newly-dead snakes. They no longer knew what to believe, since they could trust only his ability to use those things against them. No amount of insistence from the teachers would convince the little girls that rhinoceros beetles were harmless, that they are clumsy and short-sighted.

The women held their secrets because when they mentioned it to their husbands or brothers they were laughed at. The husbands and brothers told them it was mere bluff. Instead of sympathy, the husbands and brothers now had a secret weapon. Some of the women found the tails of mice or lizards between their sheets; others found grasshopper legs in their drawers of underwear.

The women learnt to hold their tongues for fear of generating ideas.

So what happened? The expected and the unexpected. Instead of a glorious career, he joined a government department as a clerk. Later his colleagues said of him that his only outstanding feature was that he kept to himself. None knew that he had grown up in the country, nor did any of them know the names of his friends. Some reported that they had seen him in the pub after work with

various women whose names they could not remember - was it Anne, Jane, Margaret, Felicity, Carole? No one could remember.

He resigned without proper notice one Friday and never returned to his desk. They did not know that by the time the new week had started his plane was landing in a country half a day's flight away. He knew his skills would be rewarded there. And so they were. By the time he returned, eight years later, he had enough money to buy a large and imposing property on a secluded block overlooking the sea.

It wasn't until the trial that anyone knew anything more about him.

It was in all the papers; in particular, it was in the newspaper of his home town. The papers were liberal in their detail - to the point of obscenity. Suffice it here to say that in his imposing property he had treated women as he had always treated every living thing.

The men of his home town said, But how could it happen? How could he change into a monster like this? But the women, who had been little girls, knew that he had not changed.

Clues?

- In your group; discuss your initial reactions to 'Rhinoceros Beetle'.
- It is possible to read the text as providing 'early warning signs' of the boy's later behaviour. On your own, skim the text, marking with the label 'HINT', those references that you consider could be read as an indication of the kind of story to follow.
- If you were trying to hint at the boy's later behaviour, in the manner of a film trailer which details from the text would you select to give readers clues about the kind of story they were about to read? Try it out with a partner, using no more than five details from the text.
- Share your hints or 'trailers' in a class discussion.